

L1.5 DeepSeek API: Connecting

Level: Foundation (Free) **Time:** 15-20 minutes **Type:** Practical API account + connection **Author:** Adi Ciobanu LeYa Academy **You need:** Hermes Agent installed (L1.4) + internet + ~\$5 on a card (DeepSeek initial credit)

What you'll know by the end

- How to create a DeepSeek account and get an API key
 - How to connect the API key to Hermes Agent
 - How to have your first conversation with your personal AI assistant
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Preamble: The AI Provider Landscape (2026)

Before we connect to DeepSeek, here are your options.

Provider	Model	Cost	Strengths	Weaknesses
DeepSeek	V3/V4	~\$0.50/1M tokens	Best quality/price ratio	Lesser-known brand
OpenAI	GPT-4o	~\$15/1M tokens	Mature ecosystem, tools	Expensive, data through US
Anthropic	Claude	~\$15/1M tokens	Best long-form reasoning	Expensive, geo-limited
Google	Gemini	Free (up to a limit)	Free for low volume	Frequent API changes
Local	Gemma/Llama	\$0	Total privacy	Slower, less capable

Why DeepSeek V4 for this course?

- **Unbeatable cost** ~\$0.50 per MILLION tokens (~750,000 words). Roughly 30x cheaper than OpenAI/Claude.
- **Competitive quality** good enough for 95% of everyday tasks.
- **Stable API** no sudden changes, clear documentation.
- **128K context** you can have very long conversations without issues.
- **Globally available** no geographic restrictions.

Reminder from L1.1: DeepSeek API is a temporary bridge. In Level 3 you'll learn to run a 100% local model, with zero external APIs. Until then, DeepSeek is the fastest and cheapest way to have a working AI.

Glossary

Term	What it means
API key	A long password that authorizes Hermes to use DeepSeek. Generated once.
Token	The unit of measurement for processed text. ~1 token = ~0.75 English words.
Provider	"Who processes it?" DeepSeek in our case
Model	"Which version?" <code>deepseek-chat</code> (V4) in our case

Content

1. Create an account and get an API key

1. Go to <https://platform.deepseek.com>

2. Click **Sign Up** create an account with email or Google
3. After logging in, go to **API Keys** in the menu
4. Click **Create New Key** give it a name (e.g., “Hermes”)
5. **Copy the key immediately.** It’s shown **ONLY ONCE**. Once you close the window, you can’t see it again.

Store the key somewhere safe. Don’t post it anywhere. Don’t send it via Discord/WhatsApp/email. Only one person should have access: you.

6. Add initial credit: **\$5 is enough for months.** Go to Billing Add Credit.

2. Configure in Hermes

Add the API key:

Edit the `.env` file:

```
nano ~/.hermes/.env
```

Add this line (replace `your-key-here` with what you copied):

```
DEEPSEEK_API_KEY=your-key-here
```

Save: `Ctrl+O`, Enter, `Ctrl+X`.

Alternative: If you don’t want to use nano, you can use `echo 'DEEPSEEK_API_KEY=***' >> ~/.hermes/.env`. But be careful the key will appear in your terminal history.

Activate the provider:

```
hermes config set provider deepseek
```

Set the model:

```
hermes config set model deepseek-chat
```

Why two commands? **Provider** = who processes it (DeepSeek). **Model** = which version (deepseek-chat = V4). You can change them independently anytime.

3. Your first conversation

```
hermes chat
```

You’ll enter chat mode. Type:

```
Hello! Who are you and what can you do?
```

If the response is coherent and in the language you configured **you did it**.

Exit chat: `Ctrl+C` or type `exit`.

First conversation issues:

Issue	Solution
“Invalid API key”	The key is wrong or expired. Check platform.deepseek.com API Keys.
“Provider not configured”	You didn’t run <code>hermes config set provider deepseek</code> . Run it now.
“Connection timeout”	Check your internet. <code>ping platform.deepseek.com</code> does it respond?
“Insufficient balance”	Add \$5 credit at platform.deepseek.com Billing
Response is gibberish/wrong language	Check your language setting: <code>hermes config get language</code> . Set to <code>en</code> or <code>ro</code> .

Exercise

1. Create a DeepSeek account and get your API key
2. Add \$5 credit (enough for months of use)
3. Configure Hermes with the DeepSeek provider and model
4. Have your first conversation take a screenshot of the first exchange

What you’ve achieved: A working AI, with personality, running on your machine. Everything you add from here memory, skills, voice, sensors is built on this foundation.

Checkpoint don’t move on until you can answer

1. Is your API key saved in `.env`?

Check: `cat ~/.hermes/.env` you should see `DEEPSEEK_API_KEY=***` Don’t post the output anywhere. Just verify the line exists.

2. Which DeepSeek model did you configure?

Check: `hermes config get model`. It should say `deepseek-chat`.

3. What was the first thing your assistant said to you?

Expected: A coherent sentence something like “I’m an AI assistant...” or “I can help you with...”. If it’s gibberish check the issues table above.

If you’ve made it here and all 3 are correct: **congratulations. You’ve completed Level 1.** You built a working AI. Zero subscription. Your data on your machine.

What’s next? Level 2 Personalization. You’ll teach your assistant who you are, how to speak, and connect it to your phone.

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